

Christmas Bombing

In the closing weeks of 1972, the United States planned a high-intensity bombing campaign, codenamed Linebacker II, that had both military and diplomatic objectives. This onslaught took place over 11 days, starting on December 19, 1972.

◀◀ BEFORE

By late 1972, domestic pressure to end US involvement in the war and bring prisoners of war home from Hanoi was becoming intense.

NEGOTIATING SUCCESS

In October 1972, the North Vietnamese negotiator at the Paris peace talks, Le Duc Tho, agreed that **President Thieu could remain in power** in the South after a ceasefire was signed. However, Thieu was unhappy that the draft ceasefire agreement did not insist on the NVA leaving the South and **the talks came to a halt**.

B-52S IN PLACE

In preparation for a winter bombing campaign, a B-52 force was assembled in nearby countries by late 1972. Meanwhile, the North Vietnamese were **evacuating civilians** from Hanoi.

When the peace talks in Paris broke down on December 13, US forces were already gathering for Linebacker II, a successor to the Linebacker I bombing campaign that had ended in October. Ostensibly, the reason was to force North Vietnam back to the negotiating table, but as recordings of President Nixon's December 16 meetings with Vice President Spiro T. Agnew and Henry Kissinger reveal, the true aim of Linebacker II was to convince President Thieu that the US promise to execute massive retaliation against the North was not an empty one. That way, the Saigon leader might stop blocking the peace agreement.

Ready and waiting

Hanoi expected the attack. General Van Tien Dung had approved the final defense plan on November 24, and had ordered that everything be ready by December 3. Hanoi knew that a night attack would hamper their defense efforts: their fighter interceptors mostly lacked onboard radars and their antiaircraft gunners needed to see their targets.

On the morning of December 18, President Nixon telephoned Admiral Moorer, chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, to emphasize that Linebacker II represented the military's last chance to hit hard at the DRV.

That evening, B-52s in the lead wave took off from Thailand, flew up the Mekong River valley and approached Hanoi. Navy and Air Force attack planes entered from seaward hoping to distract the North Vietnamese. There were 129 B-52s in the strike. The lead bomber, piloted by Captain Hal Wilson, reported wall-to-wall surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) ahead. About an hour into the raid NVA headquarters learned a SAM from the 261st Missile Regiment had downed a B-52. Two more would be lost that night, one of them Captain Wilson's.

Over the succeeding days the attacks continued, with a halt for Christmas itself. The bombers blasted air defenses, railroads, and industries; tactical aircraft added armed reconnaissance. The North Vietnamese tried mass firings of SAMs, missile launchings in unguided mode, fighter intercepts, even a deliberate midair crash. The Americans lost 15 B-52s and nine more were damaged, out of 795 B-52 sorties. Tactical aircraft flew 640 sorties and lost seven planes. Nearly 40 US airmen were taken prisoner.